A key challenge facing outside experts working on foreign and security policy issues is the issue of classification. As one expert noted, almost nothing gets declassified and so those in the government or in government-affiliated think tanks have an advantage. The Ministry of External Affairs has the Indian Council of World Affairs (ICWA) at Sapru House and Research and Information System for Developing Countries (RIS). The Ministry of Defence has the Institute for Defence and Strategic Analysis (IDSA) and the United Services Institute (USI).

Most outside experts as well as retired and serving diplomats and officials agree that compared to a decade ago there is more outside input or as one stated, there is greater osmosis between universities, government and think tanks. As a former foreign minister noted, you cannot depend on the brilliance of an officer or a minister or prime minister, you need outside inputs for difficult policy decisions. The same politician pointed out that he was a subscriber to intelligence publications like *Jane's Defence*, *Oxford Analytica* and others.[57]

One of the reason for recent changes is that a majority of the analysts in think tanks are former civil servants, even diplomats, and so it is easier for them to ensure that their views reach their peers. However, experts cautioned that it still depends on the individual and is not institutionalized. As an example many stated that when Indira called upon someone of the calibre of K. Subrahmanyam, who was then director, Institute for Defence and Strategic Analysis, for advice it was in his individual capacity. As a former foreign secretary noted cynically, everything in India is personal.[58]

Although India has come a long way since the days of Nehru's idealism, it is still more a nation hoping to be a great power than a great power with a well-defined strategic culture.